School Districts in California Are Lagging Behind in Environmental Action

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INTRODUCTION

- The urgency of climate change calls for the need to teach people of challenges that our environment faces, prepare to be safe against our environment, and to take action to protect our planet
- Schools are the best place to build climate
- In 2015, the California Department of Education created a Blueprint for Environmental Literacy
- In Ten Strands, "A Watershed Moment for Environmental Literacy..", Gerald Lieberman writes more about the changes to our education systems that encourage environmental literacy
- These works establish the importance of environmental literacy and now, we want to continue to track the progress over time by analyzing indicators
- Mapping out the numerous climate-based education that schools are implementing can help track progress toward stronger climate education

RESEARCH QUESTION

To what extent has each school district in California advanced forward environmental and climate action within their schools and overall district?

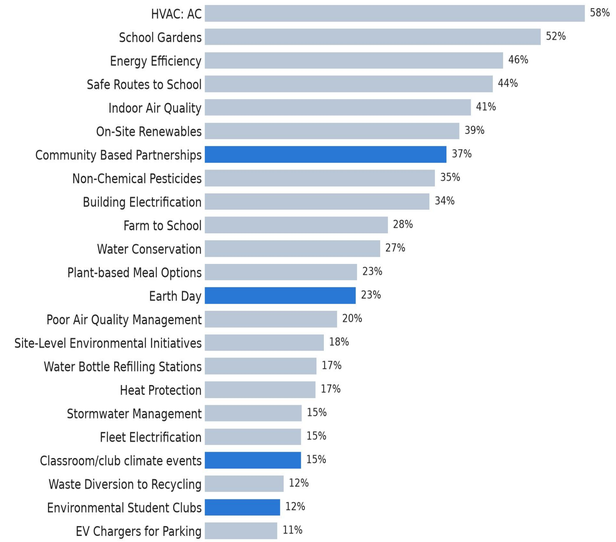
And what are the common indicators that demonstrate environmental and climate action within a school/district's campus, curriculum, and community and culture?

DATA COLLECTION

- Collected data on Action in Community like committees, and Awards like local sustainability awards
- Recorded each district to its CDS code
- Sources used include district websites, board policies, district social media, and local news
- Used a combination of LLM-assisted search and manual verification
- We encountered a high sparsity for some indicators, which could indicate that they are not common across the state or a high rate of false negatives

Which climate practices do districts publicly document?

Share of districts with a documented "yes" · the 23 practices documented by at least 10% of districts
Dark blue = community & student engagement practices

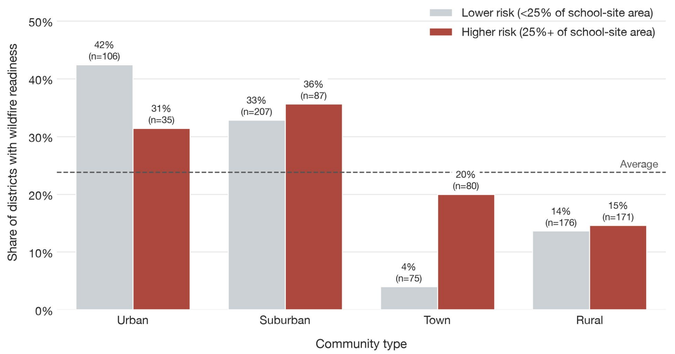


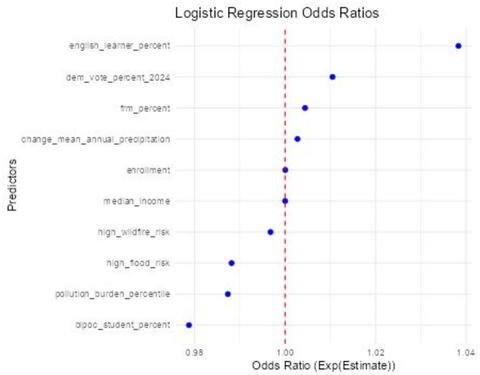
Source: Ten Strands Indicator Expansion, Fa26 collected data (937 California districts).

ANALYSIS

- A higher English learner percentage is correlated with a higher likelihood of community partnerships
- A higher pollution burden percentile, and high percentage of BIPOC students are correlated with a lower likelihood of Community-Based Partnerships
- Wildfire readiness is generally lower for rural districts regardless of risk, which may be due to a lack of resources

Rural districts show lower wildfire readiness, regardless of risk





Caption: Logistic Odds Regression Ratios for Prediction Model of Community-Based Partnerships

CONCLUSION

- Most indicators are very uncommon, which indicates both a lack of documentation and a lack of environmental efforts across California
- Most districts not prepared for wildfires (72% of districts), and this is even more true for rural districts
- Districts in economically disadvantaged and Republican-leaning document fewer community practices
- This is a wakeup call to educators and policymakers to prioritize community involvement in environmental education

IMPACT

By documenting district-level environmental and climate initiatives, this project strengthens California's environmental action dataset

These findings can support comparisons across districts, reveal gaps in implementation, and guide equitable investments in climate education and sustainability.

NEXT STEPS

Continue expanding and validating district-level indicators, improve data coverage, and support the development of an interactive database that enables educators, policymakers, and communities to track environmental progress.

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